Gathering the herd
A history of population control in distributed systems

Corto Mascle

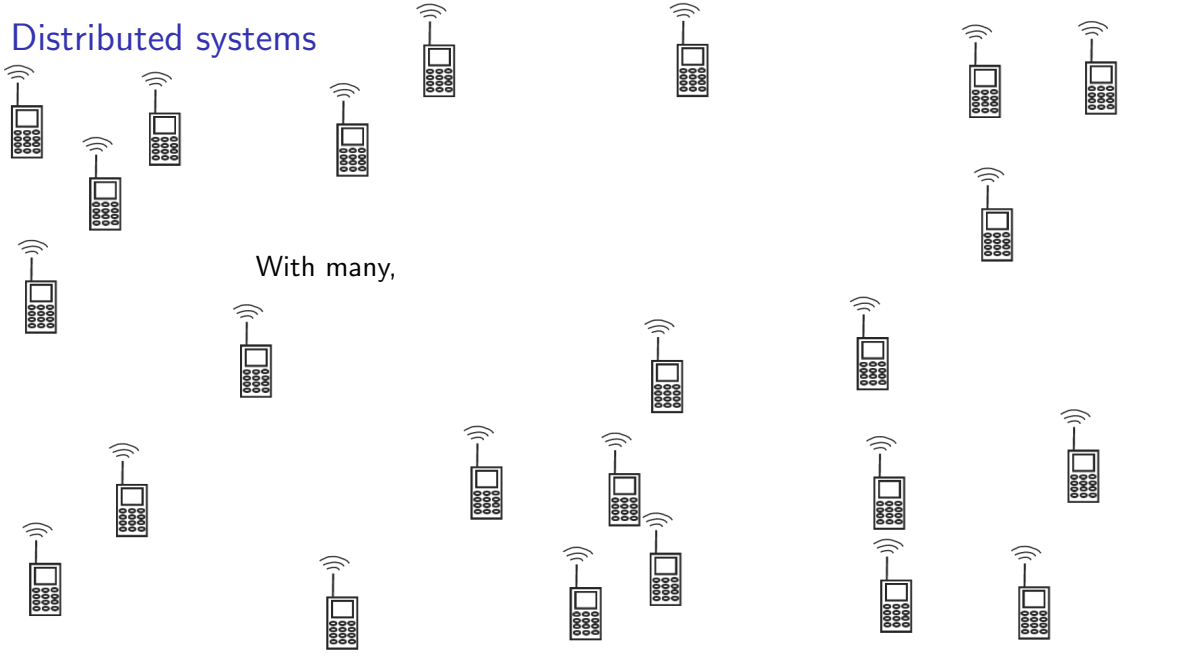
Max Planck Institute for Software Systems

GT Vérif 2026

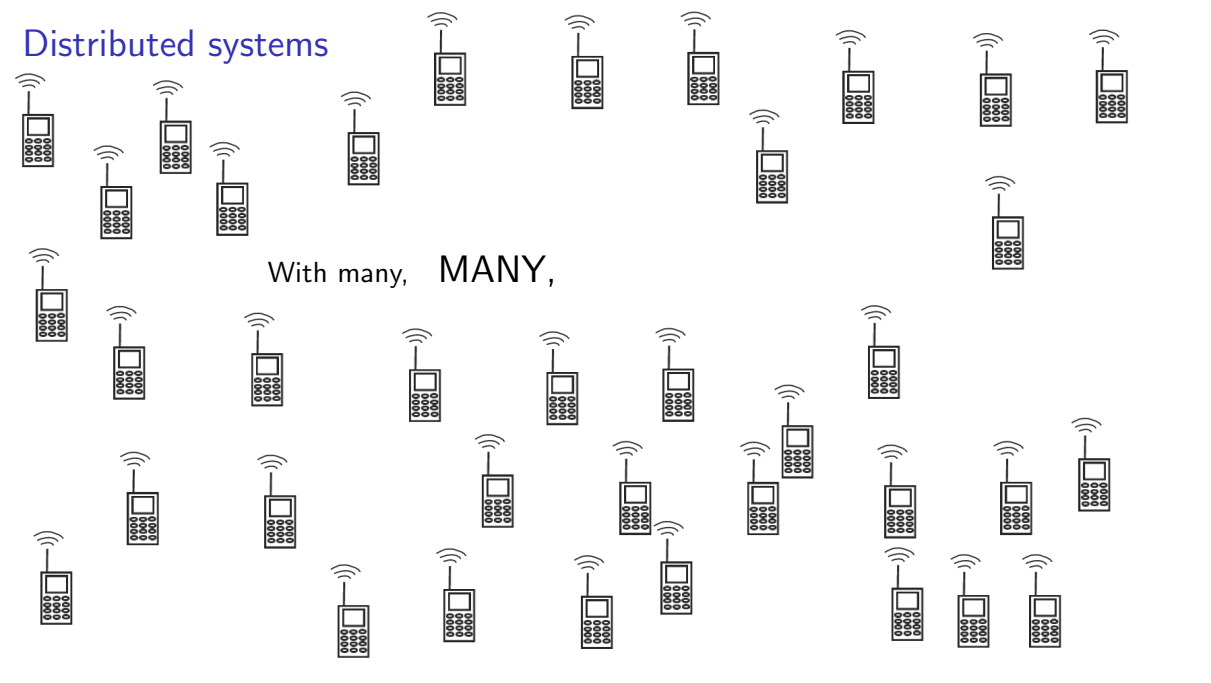
Distributed systems

Distributed systems

With many,

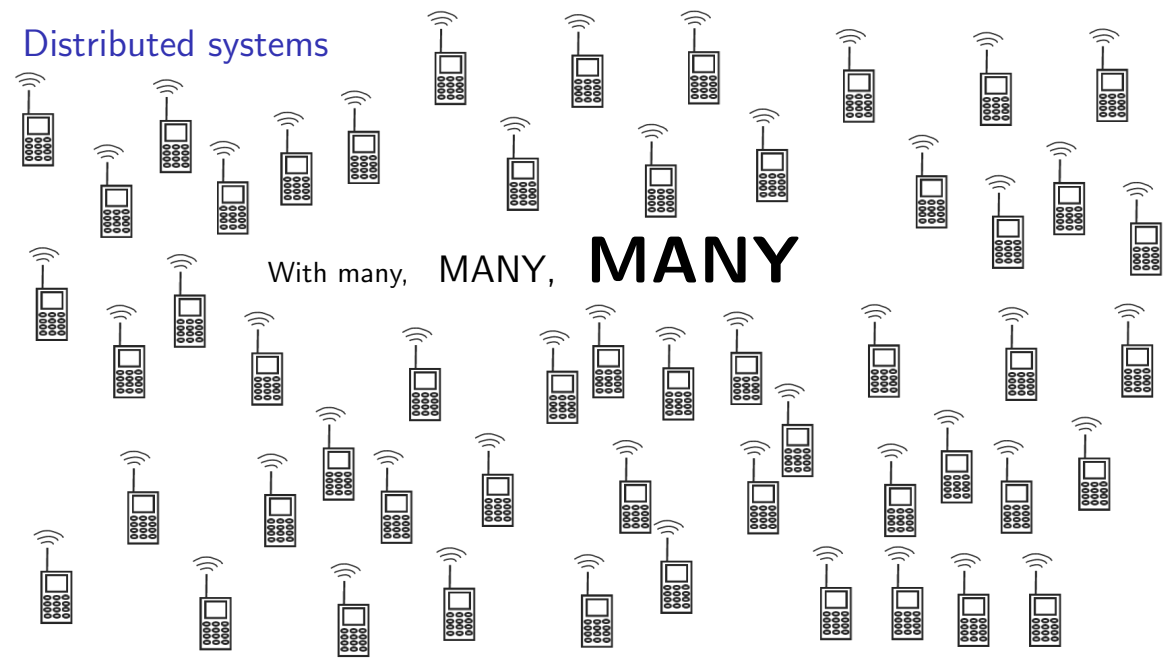


Distributed systems

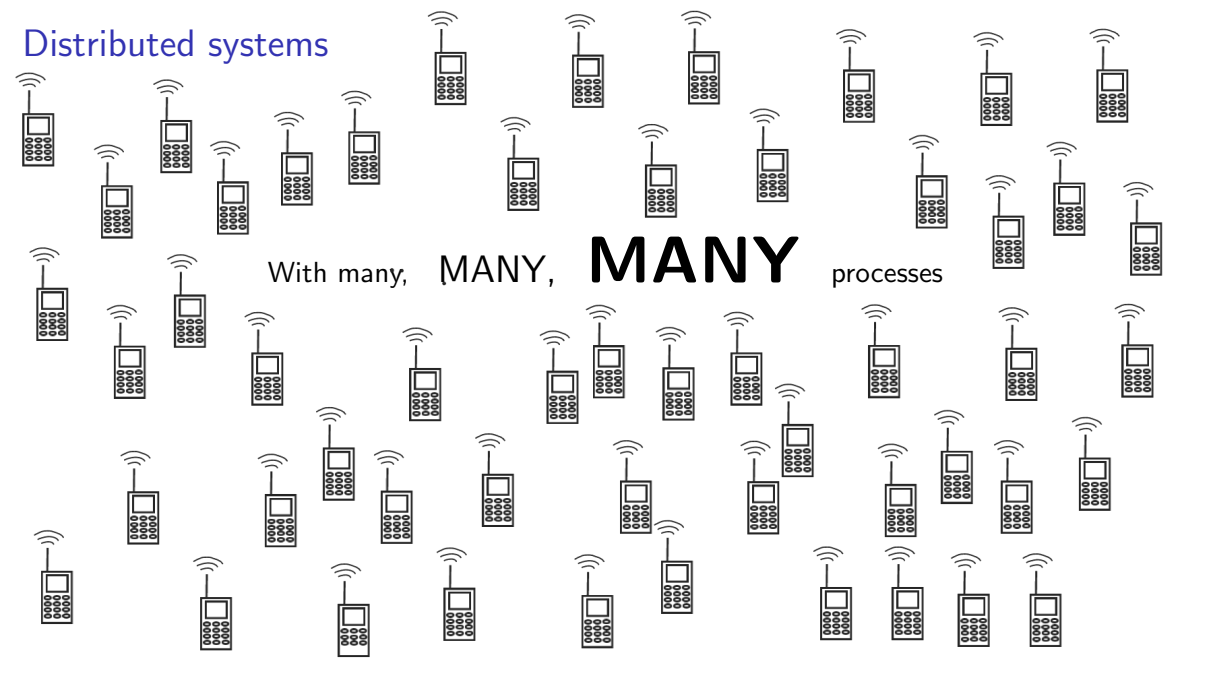


With many, MANY,

Distributed systems



Distributed systems



Distributed systems

With many, MANY, **MANY** processes

Multi-threaded programs

Distributed systems

With many, MANY, **MANY** processes

Multi-threaded programs

Client–server systems

Distributed systems

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Distributed systems

Distributed systems

Parameterized models

An arbitrary number of identical agents

Ad-hoc networks, rendez-vous protocols, ...

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Dynamic models

Number of processes may increase during runtime

Multi-threaded programs, Petri nets, ...

Distributed systems

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This talk

Dynamic models

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Parameterised verification

Given a process P, is the system of N copies of P correct

for every population size N?

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Typical systems

- Broadcast networks
- Token passing
- Mutexes
- Shared variables

Typical objectives

Safety e.g. deadlock-freeness

No bad configuration is reachable.

Liveness e.g. termination

A good behaviour eventually occurs.

Fair termination e.g. consensus

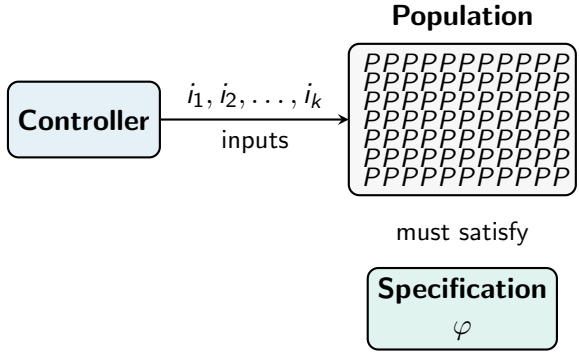
The system converges to a desired state.

Control problem

We have a system made of many identical processes.

Control problem

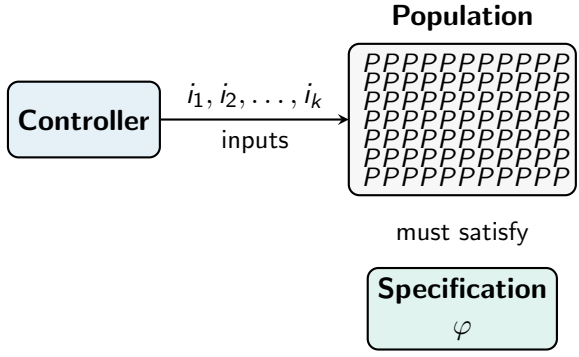
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We want a **controller** that can steer the **population** of processes to meet a given **specification**.

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Motivation

Cyber-physical systems



Parametrized Verification of Distributed Cyber-Physical Systems: An Aircraft Landing Protocol Case Study

Taylor T. Johnson and Sayan Mitra
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University of Illinois at Urbana Champaign
Urbana, IL 61801, USA
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Traffic regulation

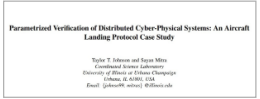


Max pressure control of a network of signalized intersections

Pravin Varaiya *
Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Sciences, University of California, Berkeley, CA 94720-1770, United States

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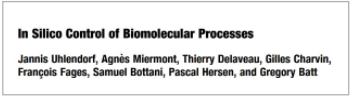
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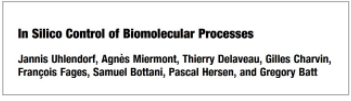


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Sociological studies

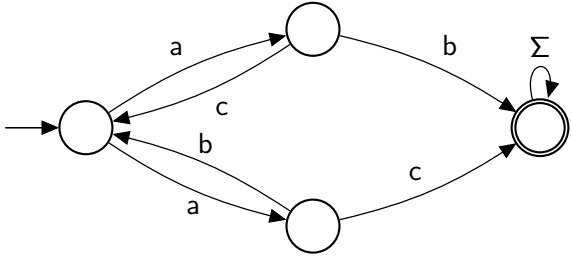


OPEN Modelling opinion dynamics under the impact of influencer and media strategies

Lucie Helfmann[1,2], Nataša Djurdjevac Conrad[1], Philipp Lorenz-Spreen[3] & Christof Schütte[1,2]✉

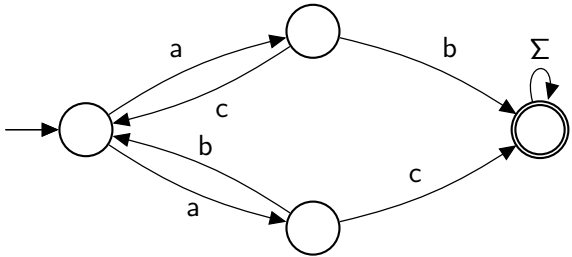
Adversarial population control [Bertrand, Dewaskar, Genest, Gimbert 2017]

$\mathcal{A}$ an NFA (= 1 process). Two players: **Controller** and **Opponent**.



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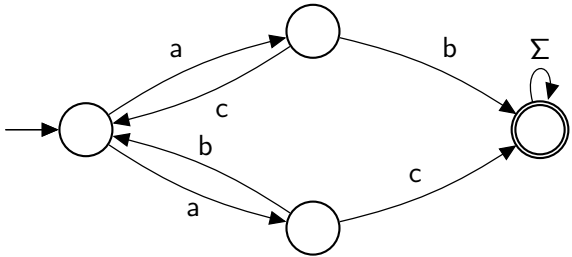
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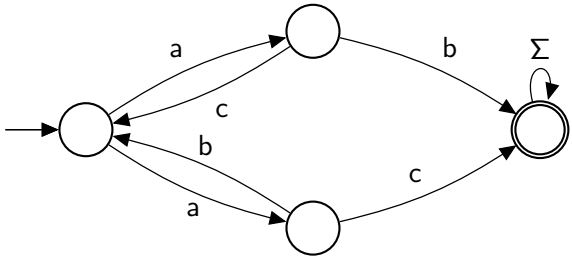
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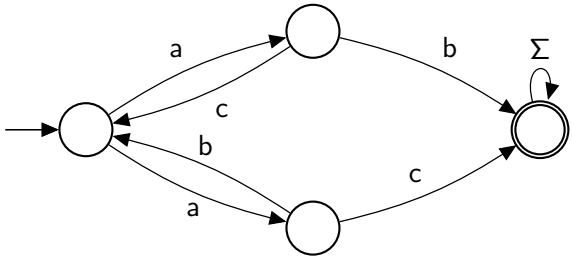
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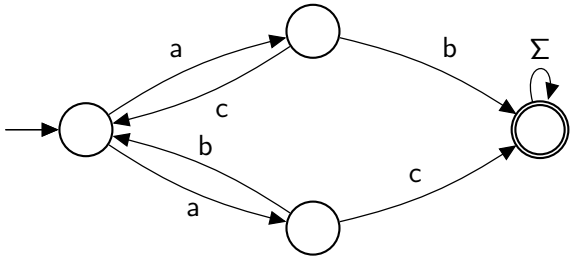
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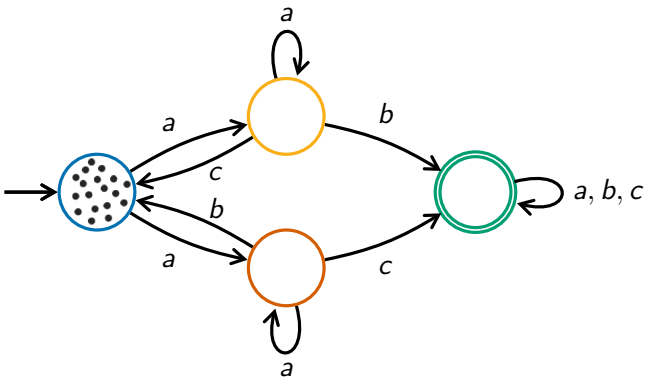
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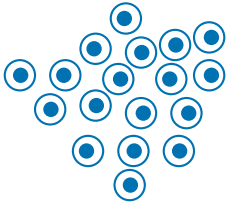
Population control problem

Input: an NFA $\mathcal{A}$

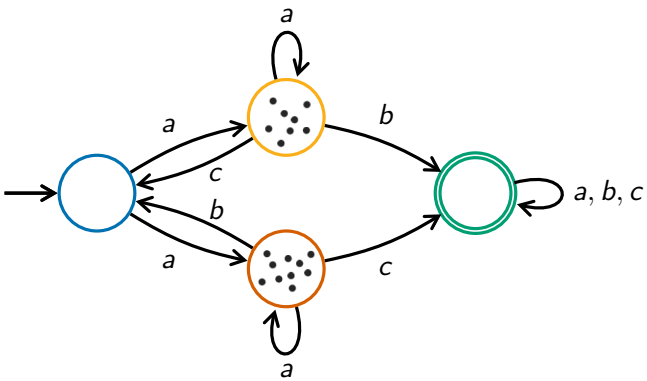
Output: Can Controller win over $\mathcal{A}$ for all N?

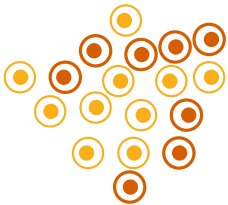
Adversarial population control



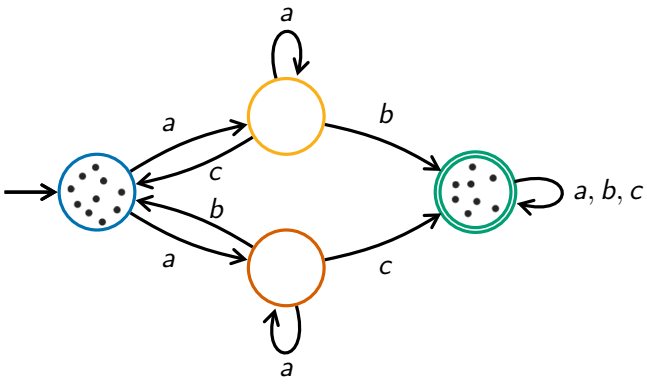


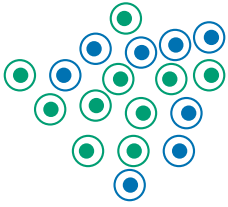
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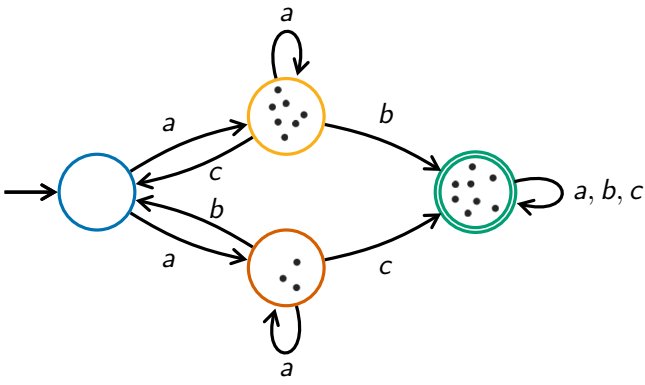


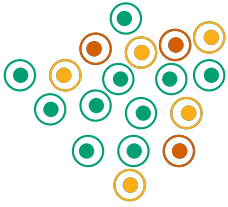
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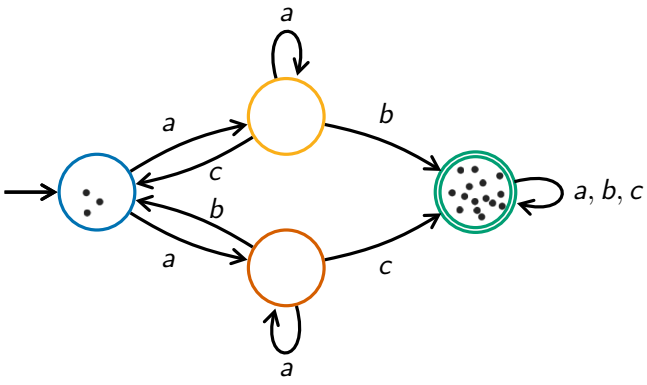


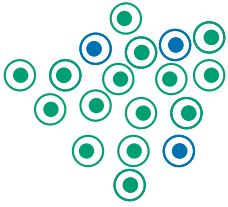
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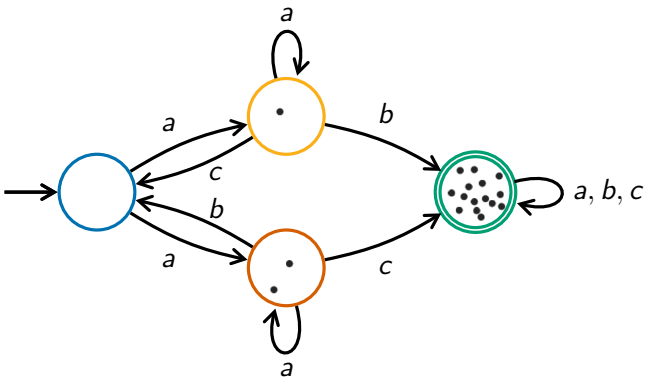


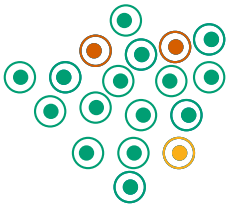
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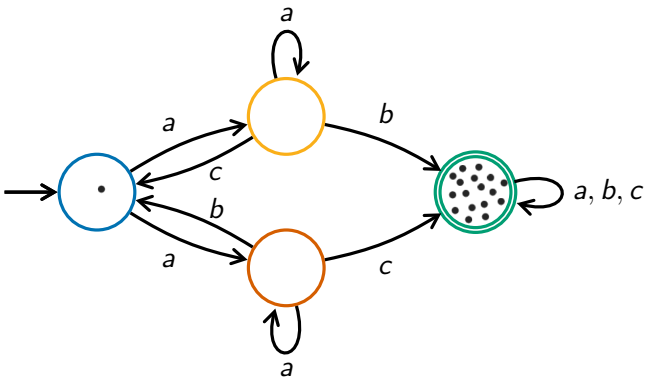


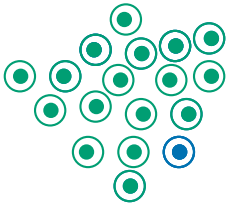
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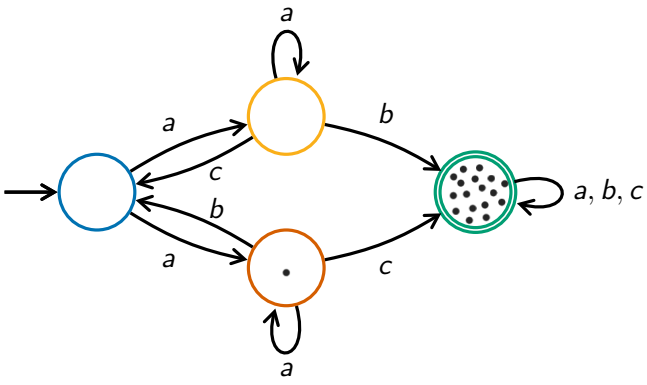


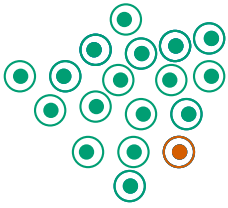
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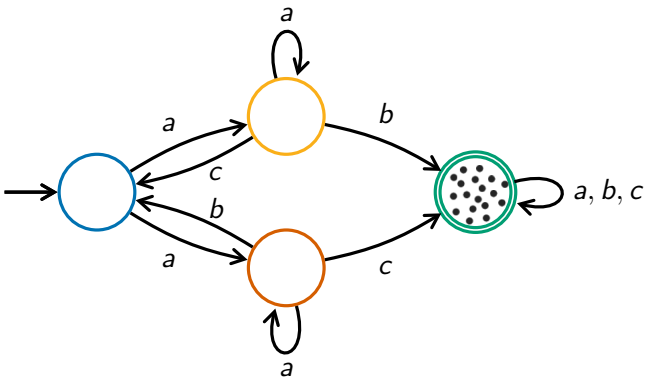


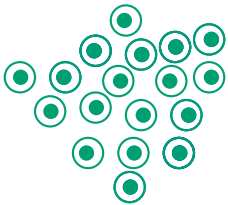
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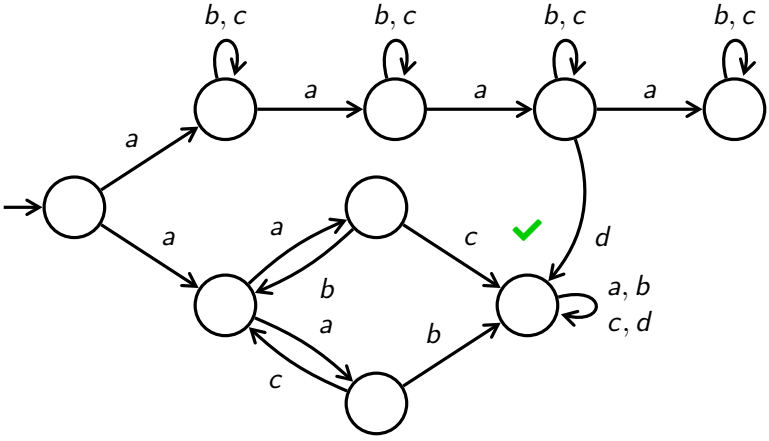


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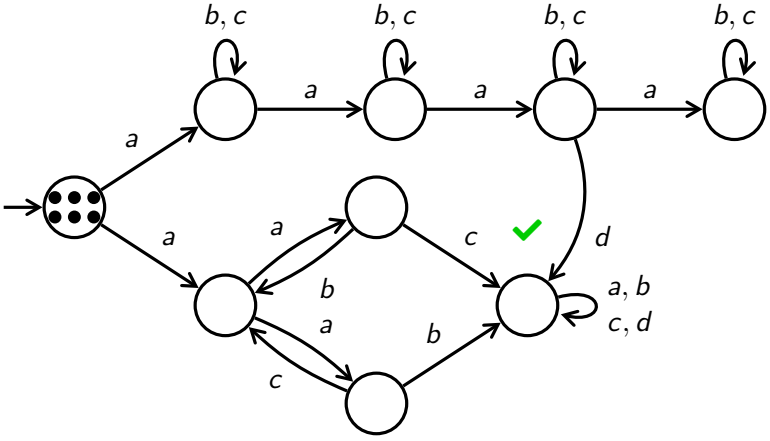




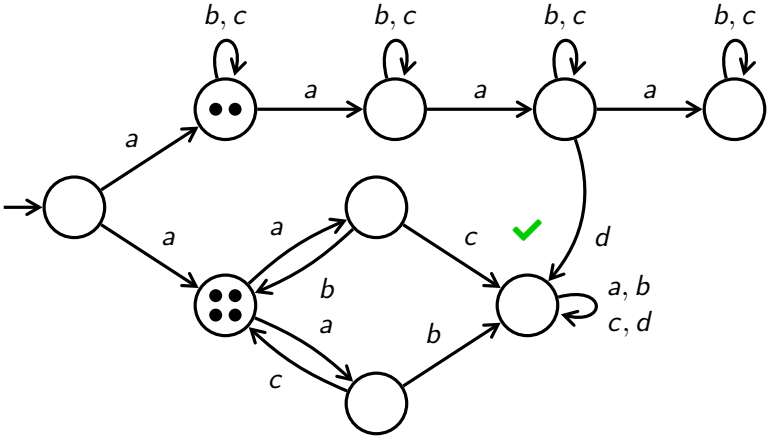
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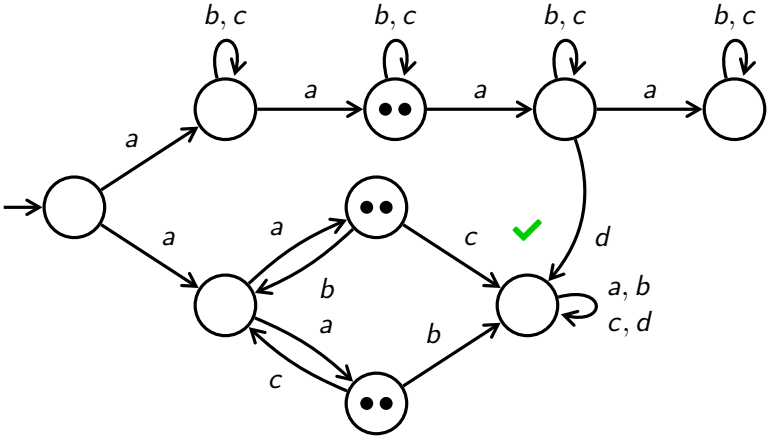
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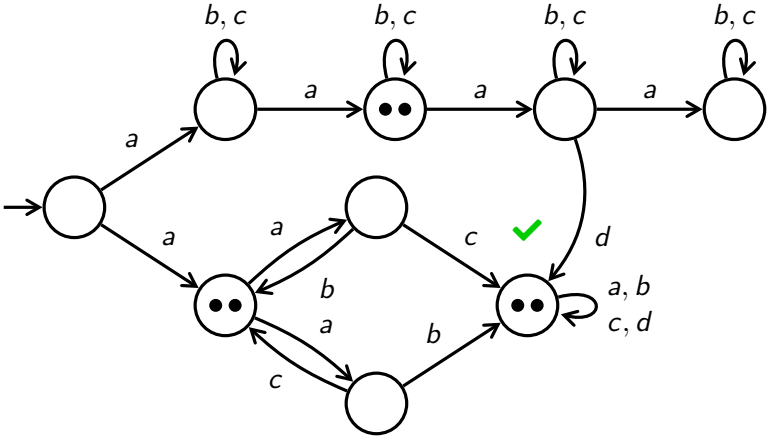
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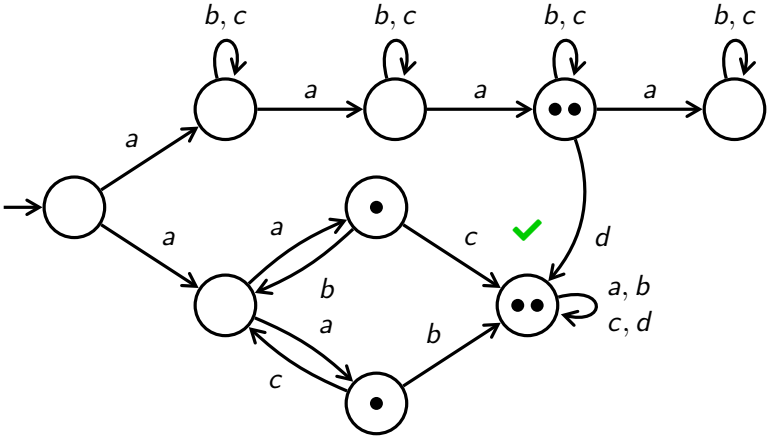
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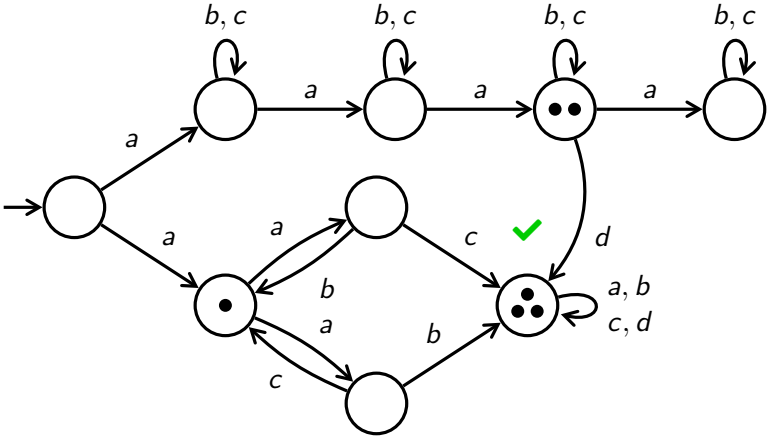
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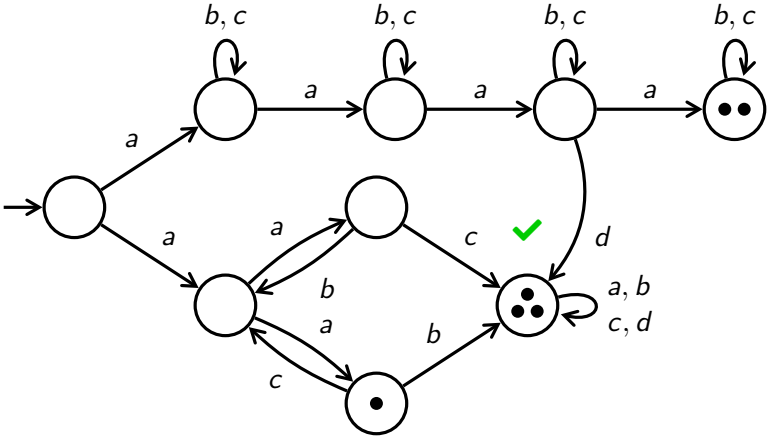
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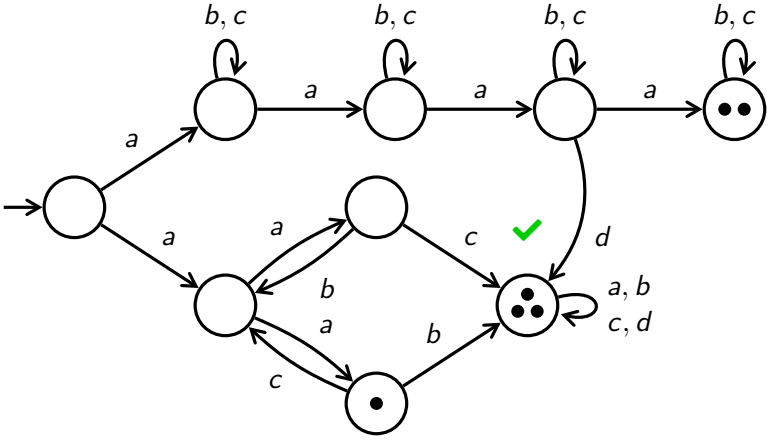
Adversarial population control



Adversarial population control



Adversarial population control



Theorem

There are NFAs of size $\mathcal{O}(k)$ for which we can win against 2^{2^k} tokens and not more.

Adversarial population control

Theorem [Bertrand, Dewaskar, Genest, Gimbert 2017]

The Adversarial Control Problem is decidable for populations of NFAs.

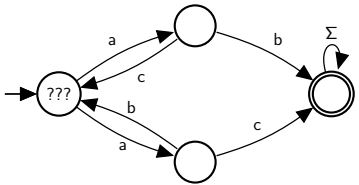
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Proof:

Hide the number of tokens!



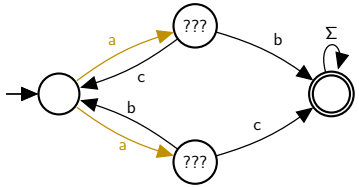
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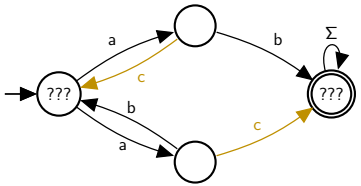
Adversarial population control

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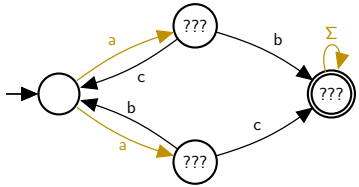
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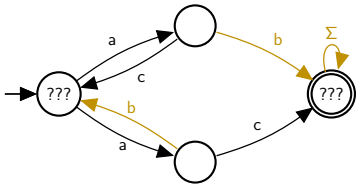
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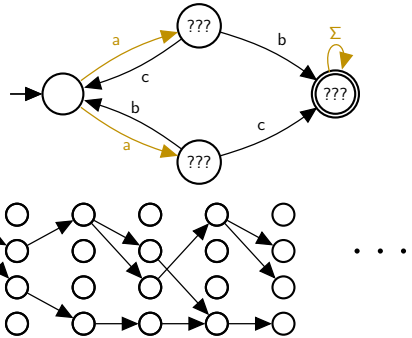
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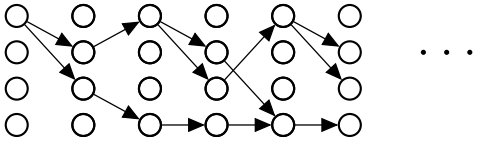
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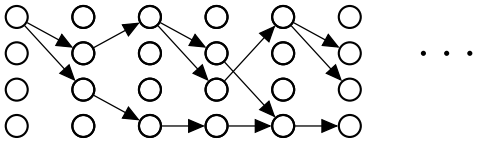


Checking the winning condition



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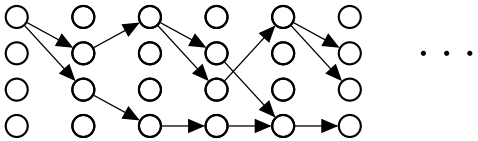


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We can construct a finite game such that Controller wins in the game if and only if she has a population control strategy for all N.

Theorem [Bertrand, Dewaskar, Genest, Gimbert 2017]

The Adversarial Population Control Problem is EXPTIME-complete.

So far...

- We have a model for populations of finite-state processes with reachability objectives
- We can decide if a controller exists for such a population!

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We assume that there is an opponent moving every process in the worst possible way.

- What happens when agents react probabilistically?

Randomised population control [Colcombet Fijalkow Ohlmann '20]

$\mathcal{A}$ an NFA ($=$ 1 process).

- We start with N processes in the initial state.

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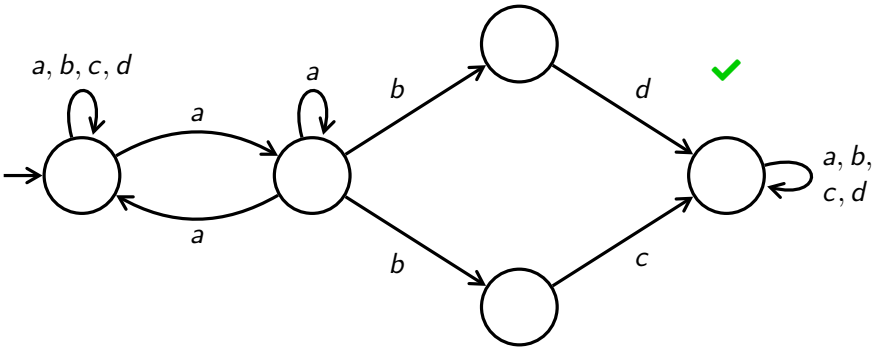
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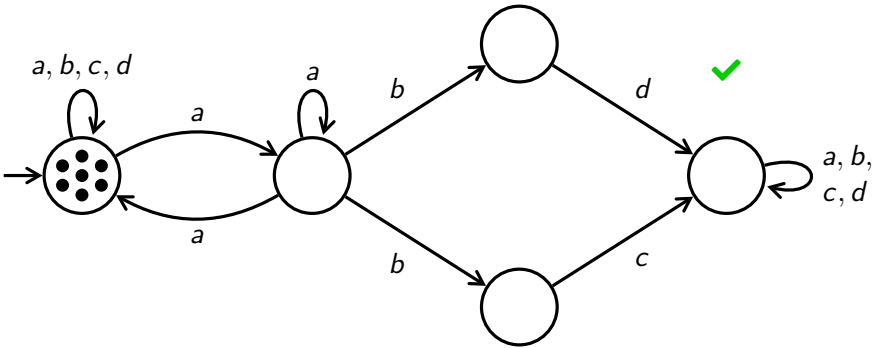
Randomised population control problem

Input: an NFA $\mathcal{A}$
Output: Can Controller win over $\mathcal{A}$ for all N **with probability 1**?

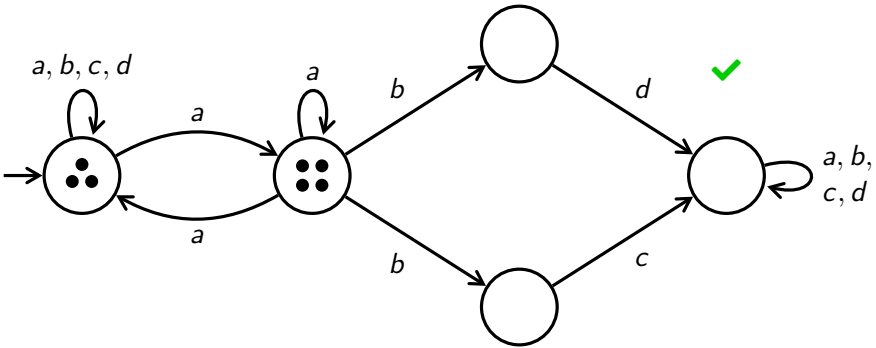
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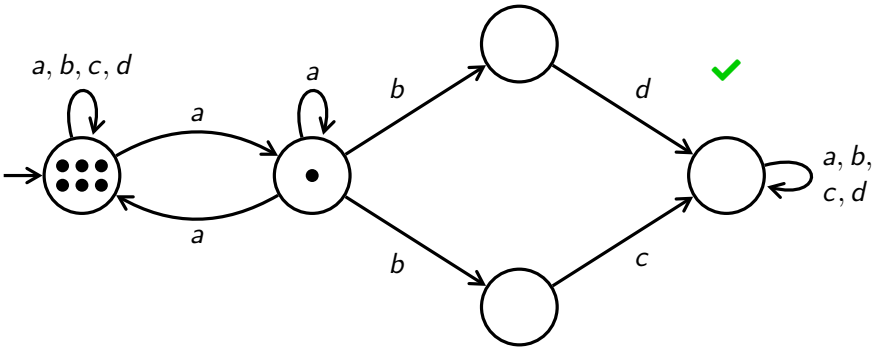
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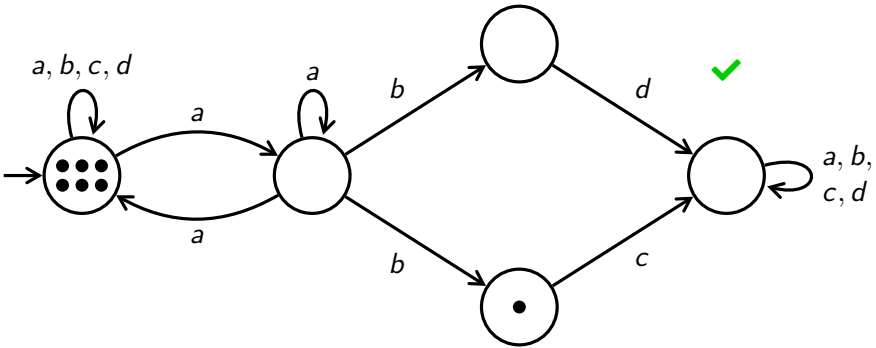
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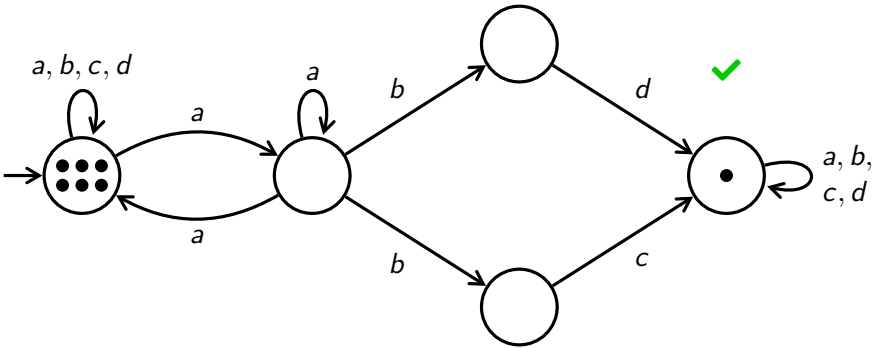
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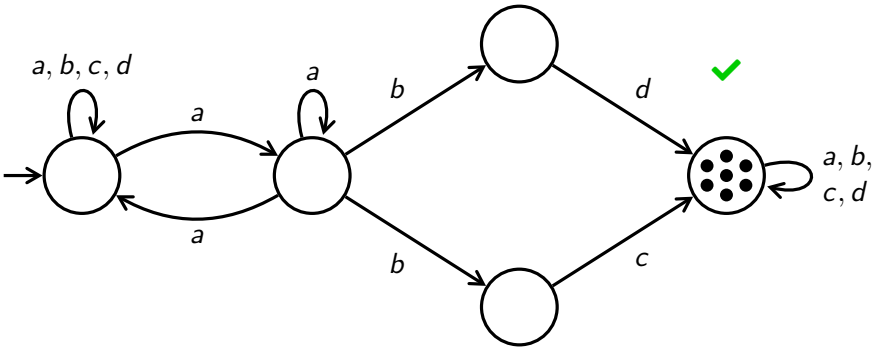
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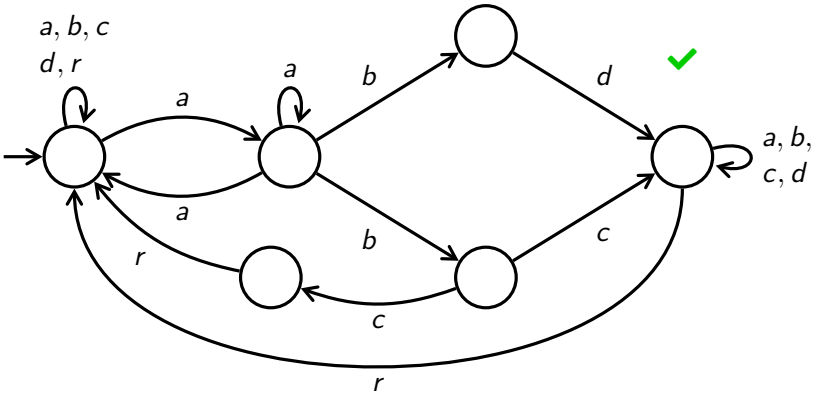
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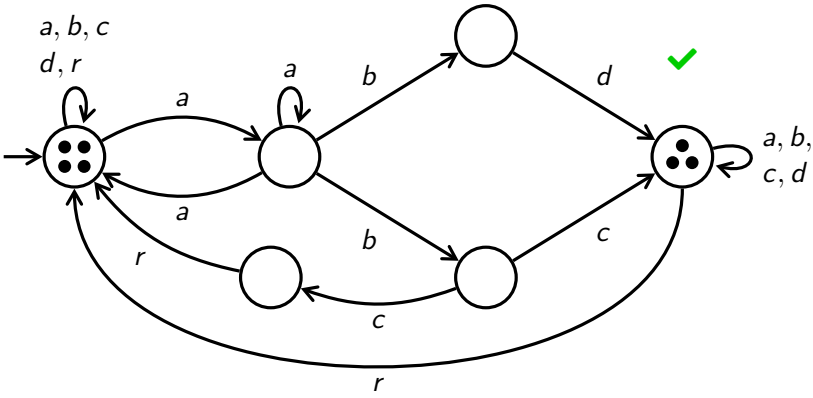
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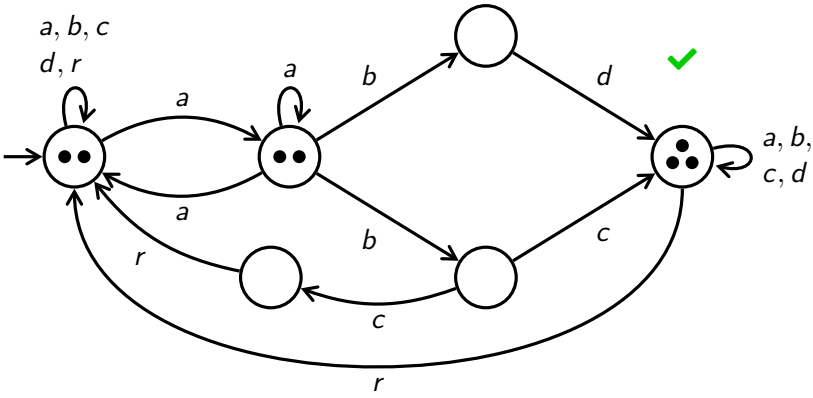
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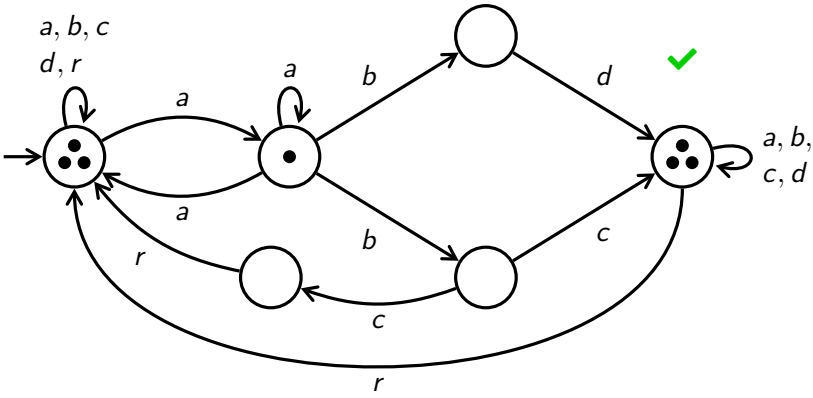
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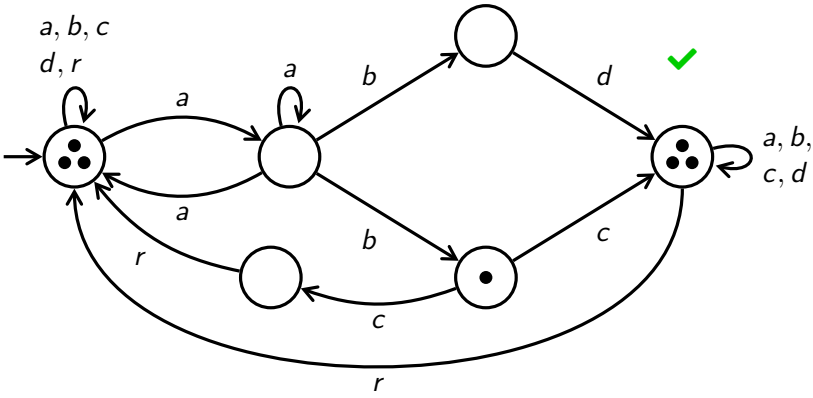
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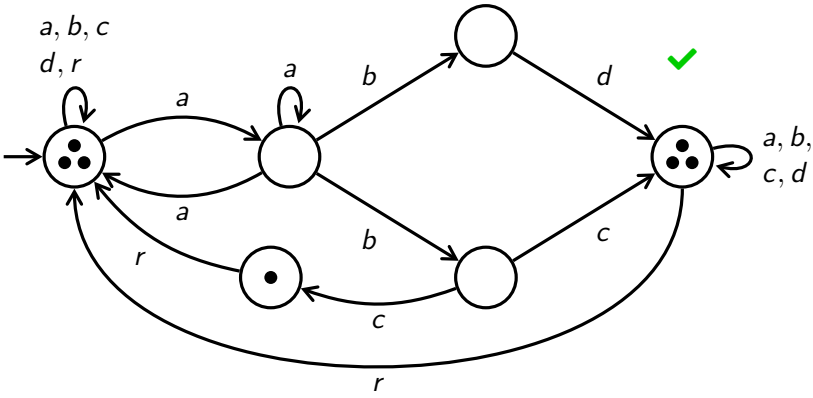
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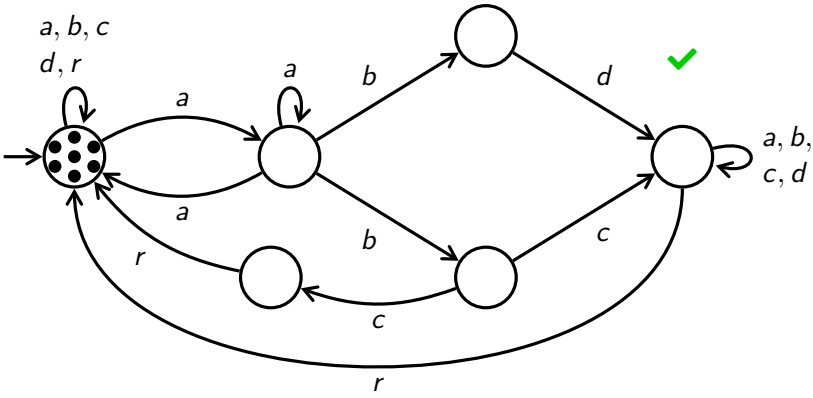
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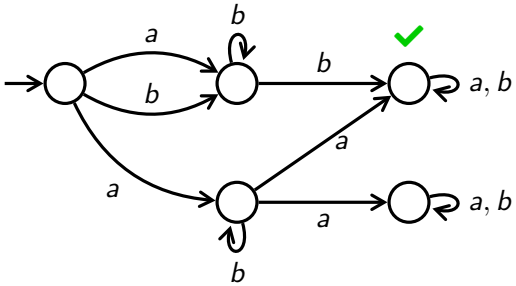
Ingredient I
Winning regions

Ingredient II
Well-quasi-orders

Ingredient III
Sequential flows

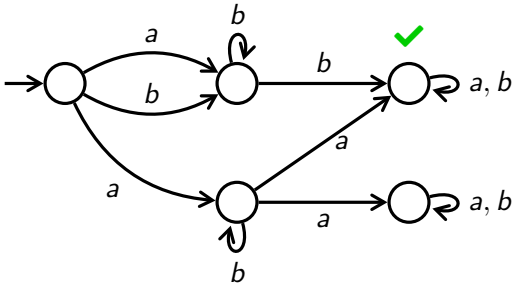
Ingredient I - Winning regions

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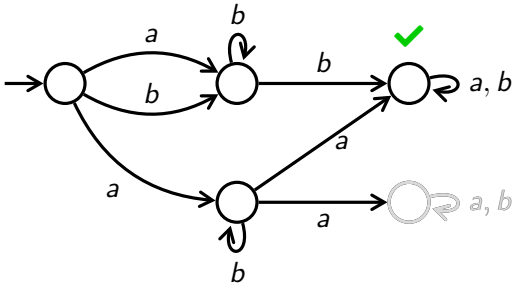
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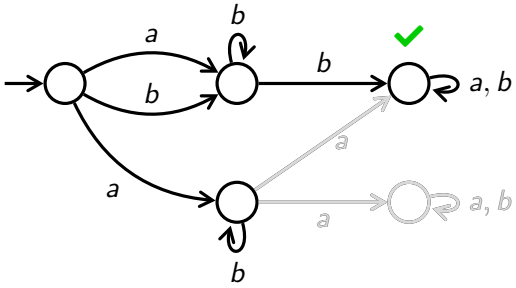
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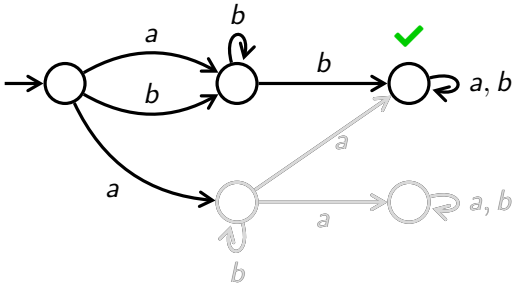
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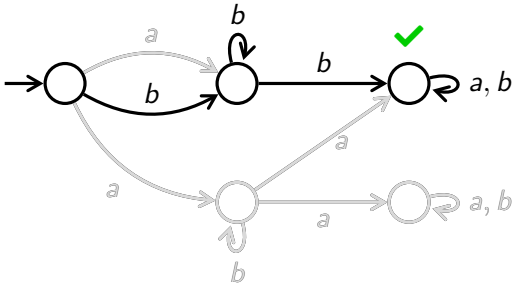
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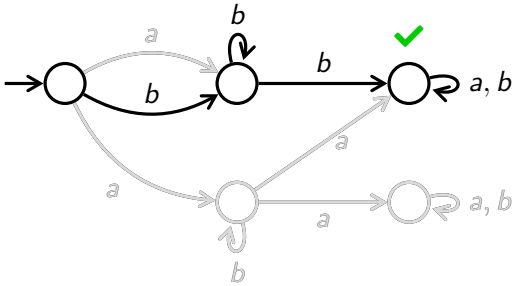
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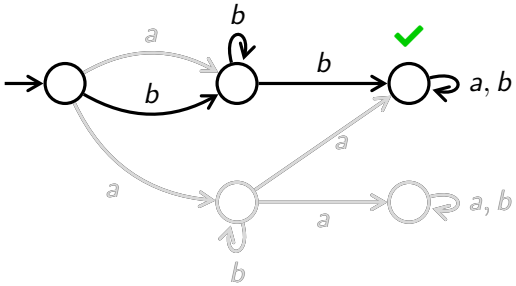
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We compute the **winning region** = set of configurations and transitions from which we can reach the target with probability 1.

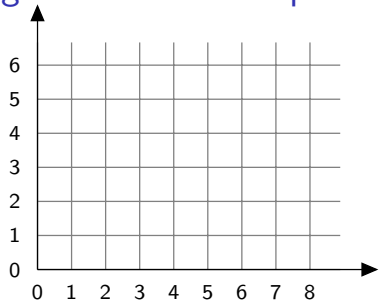
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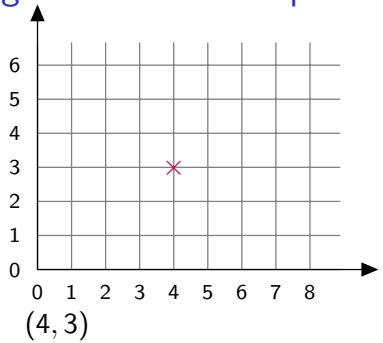
We compute the **winning region** = set of configurations and transitions from which we can reach the target with probability 1.
In general, the winning region is a subset of $\mathbb{N}^S$.

Ingredient II - Well quasi-orders



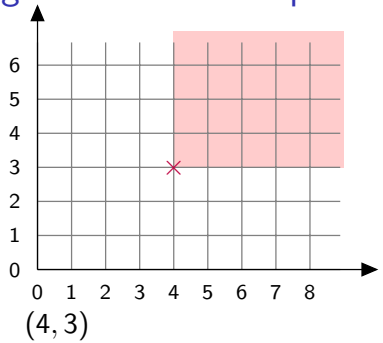
- Product ordering: $(x, y) \leq (z, t)$ when $x \leq z$ and $y \leq t$.
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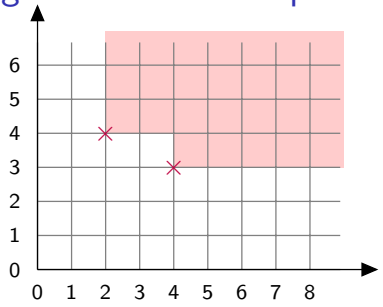
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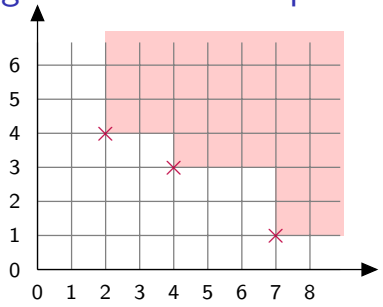
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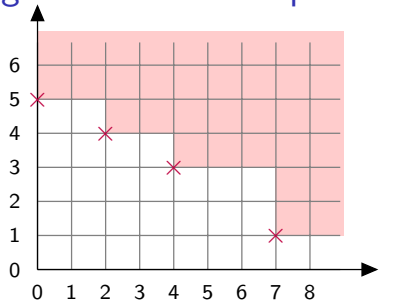
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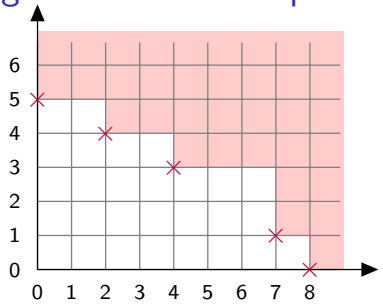
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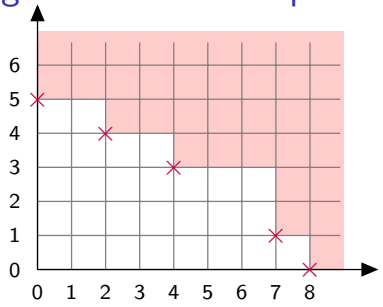
Ingredient II - Well quasi-orders



$(4,3) \to (2,4) \to (7,1) \to (0,5) \to (8,0)$

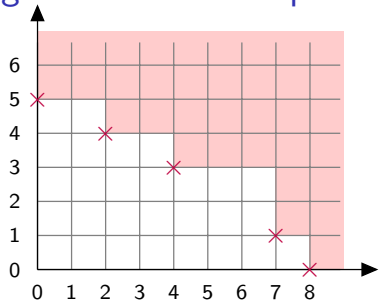
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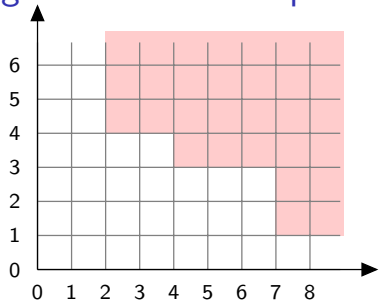
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Every set of incomparable elements for the product ordering is finite.

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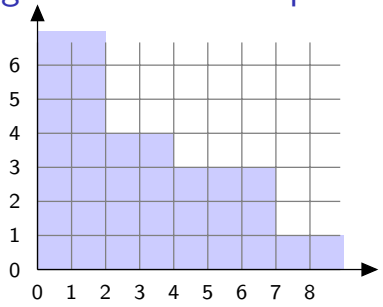


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Every downward-closed set of $\mathbb{N}^2$ has a finite representation of the form $(\omega,1)\downarrow \cup (2,\omega)\downarrow \cup (4,4)\downarrow \cup (7,3)\downarrow$.

Ingredient II - Well quasi-orders

- Fewer tokens is always better - **The winning region is downward-closed.**

Ingredient II - Well quasi-orders

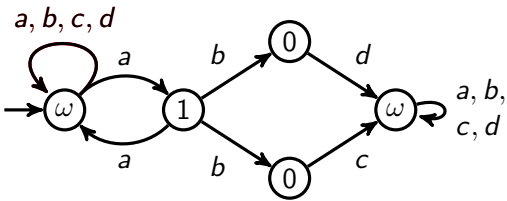
- Fewer tokens is always better - **The winning region is downward-closed.**
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$$(\omega, 5, \omega, 8)\downarrow \cup (4, \omega, \omega, 4)\downarrow \cup (9, 6, 1, 4)\downarrow$$

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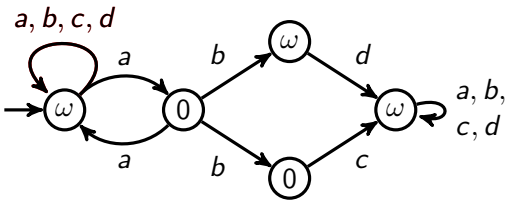
$$(\omega, 5, \omega, 8)\downarrow \cup (4, \omega, \omega, 4)\downarrow \cup (9, 6, 1, 4)\downarrow$$



Ingredient II - Well quasi-orders

- Fewer tokens is always better - **The winning region is downward-closed.**
- It can be represented as finite unions of *ideals*.

$$(\omega, 5, \omega, 8)\downarrow \cup (4, \omega, \omega, 4)\downarrow \cup (9, 6, 1, 4)\downarrow$$



Ingredient II - Well quasi-orders

Two semi-decision procedures

For each $N \in \mathbb{N}$:
If there is no strategy against N tokens
Then **NO**

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- All transitions in W are safe, and
- From each configuration in W there is a path to a target configuration within W

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Ingredient III - The sequential flow problem

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Set of states S
Tile = function
$S \times S \to \mathbb{N} \cup \{+\infty\}$

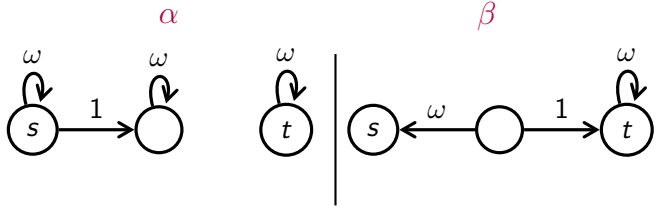
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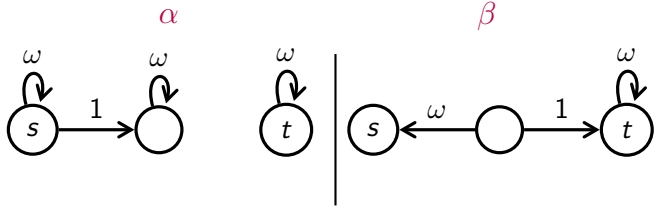
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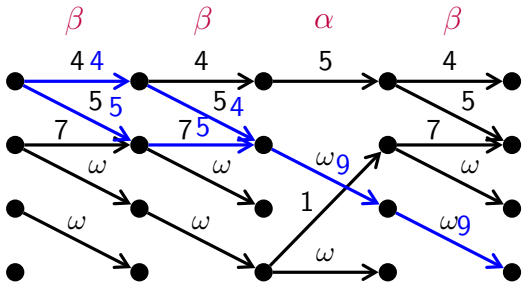
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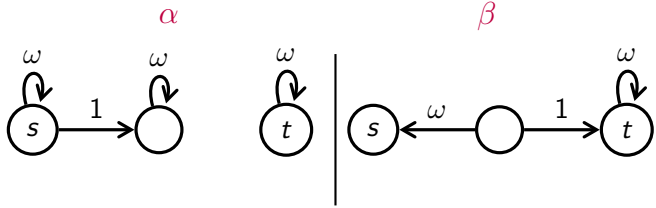
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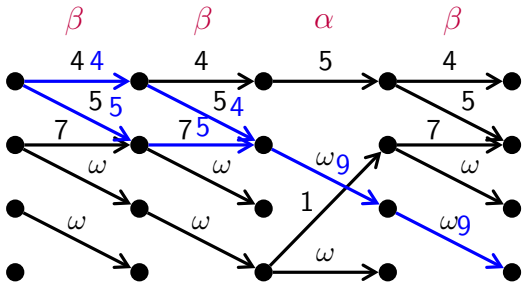
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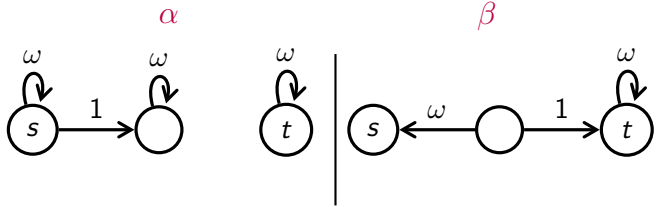
Problem [Colcombet, Fijalkow, Ohlmann '20]

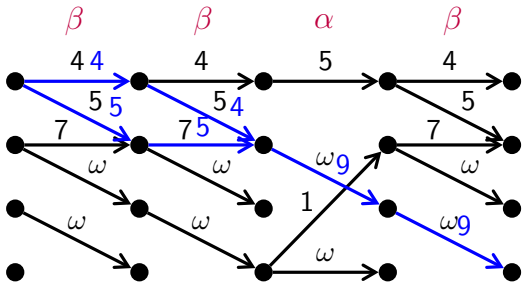
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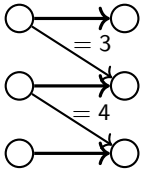


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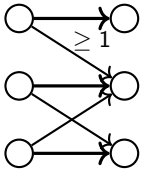
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Transfer of tokens = Flow!

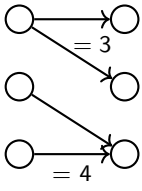
Tiles and flows



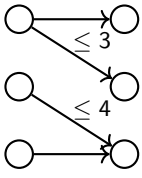
≈ Petri nets



≈Shared variables



≈Counter systems



≈ Locks

Sequential Flow Problem [Colcombet, Fijalkow, Ohlmann '20]

Problem

Input: *A set of tiles* **Tiles**
Output: *Is* $\{\texttt{MaxFlow}(w) \mid w \in \textbf{Tiles}^*\}$ *unbounded?*

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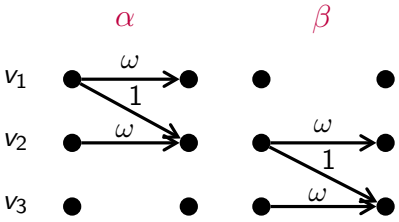
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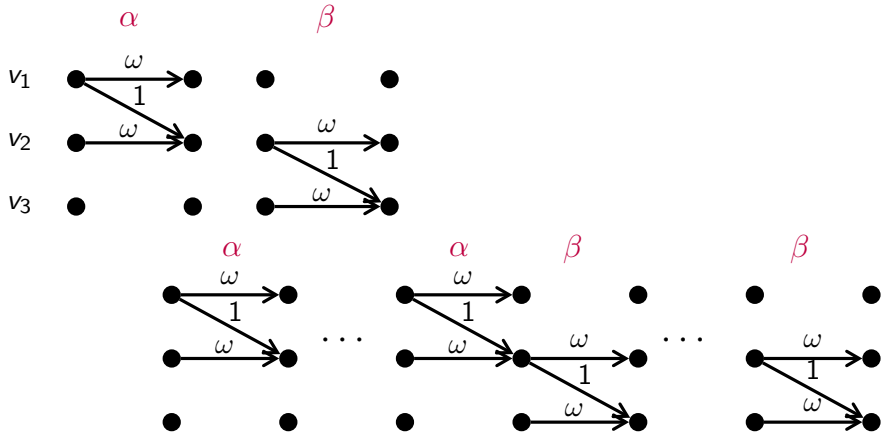
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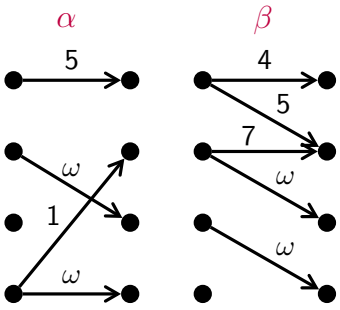
Example



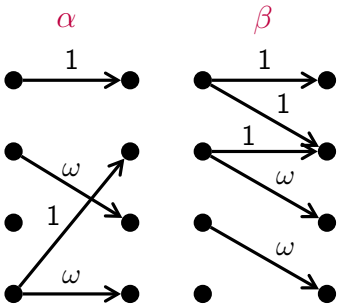
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Abstraction

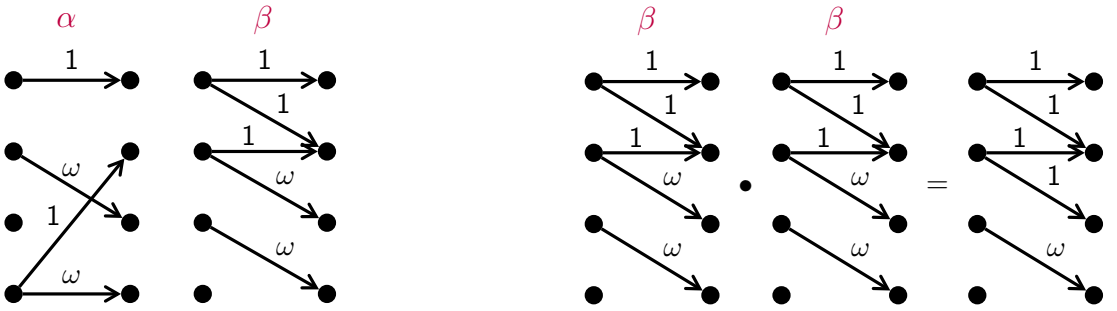


Abstraction



Morphism $\varphi : \mathbf{Tiles}^* \to \{0, 1, \omega\}^{V \times V}$ with max-min product.

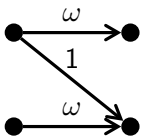
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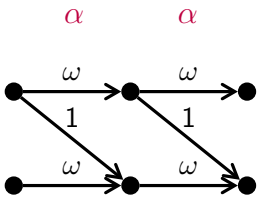
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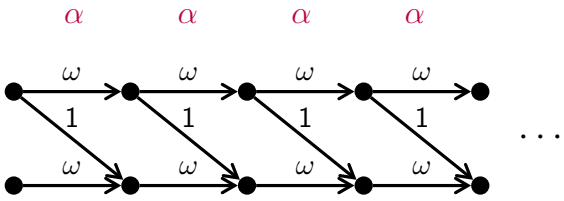
α



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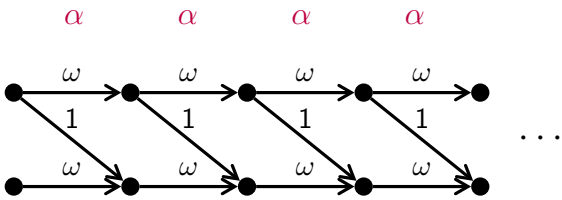


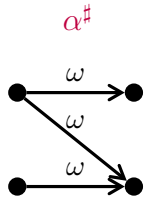
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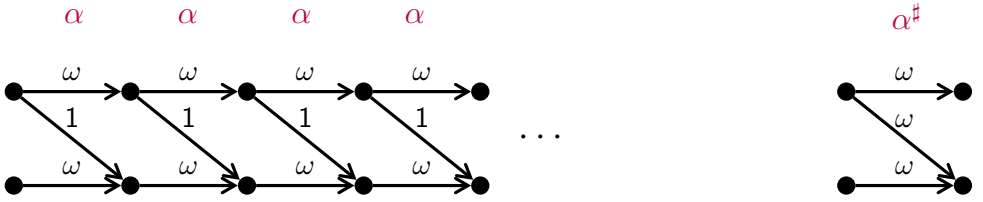


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$\mathcal{F}_\sharp$ the closure of $\varphi(\textbf{Tiles})$ under product and $\sharp$.

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What about the other direction?

Factorisation forest theorem [Simon '90]

Σ finite alphabet, $(\boldsymbol{M}, \cdot)$ finite monoid, $\varphi : \Sigma^* \to \mathbf{M}$ morphism.

Factorisation forest theorem [Simon '90]

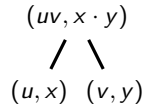
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Factorisation tree: Node labels in $\Sigma^* \times \boldsymbol{M}$.

3 types of nodes:

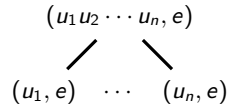
Leaves

$(a, \varphi(a))$

Product nodes



Idempotent nodes



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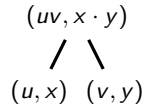
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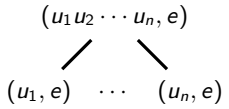
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Theorem

Every word has a factorisation tree of height $\leq 3|\mathbf{M}|$

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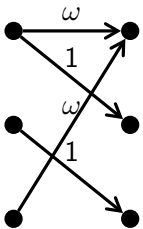
Proof by induction on the height of factorization trees.

But how large can a bounded flow be in terms of nb of vertices n?

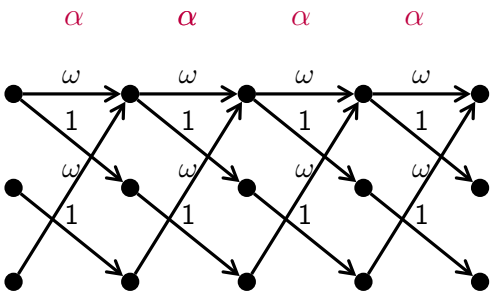
Using Simon's theorem $\rightarrow 2^{3|\mathcal{F}_\#|} \leq 2^{3^{n^2+1}}$
Can we do better?

Iteration dichotomy

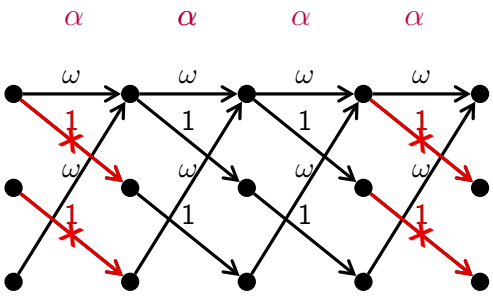
α



Iteration dichotomy



Iteration dichotomy



For all idempotent α and $s, t \in Q$,

- either $\alpha^\sharp(s,t) = \omega$
- or there is a bounded *cut* between s and t in the first and last α.

Short-ends factorisation theorem (based on work by [Simon '90], [Colcombet '11])

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Product nodes

$(uv, x \cdot y)$

(u, x) (v, y)

Idempotent nodes

$(u_1 u_2 \cdots u_n, e)$

(u_1, e) (u_n, e)

$\varphi(u_i) = e$ for all i.

Ramsey bounds (based on work by [Jecker '21])

$R_{\mathbf{M}}(k)$ = minimal n such that every word w of length n has a factor $u_1 \dots u_k$ with $\varphi(u_1) = \cdots = \varphi(u_k) = e$ an idempotent of $\mathbf{M}$.

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Theorem

For all $w \in \Sigma^*$, there is a short-ends factorisation of height $poly(log(\mathbf{M}), log(R_{\mathbf{M}}(3)))$.

Corollary

In a transition monoid $\{\top, \bot\}^{n \times n}$, every word has a short-ends factorisation of height $poly(n)$.

Exponential bound

- Every word has a factorisation of polynomial height in n.
- If there is a bounded cut between s and t in a sequence of tiles, then there is one that lives within the factorisation.

Theorem

If the flow between s and t is bounded then it is at most exponential in n.

Results

Theorem [Colcombet, Fijalkow, Ohlmann '20]

The Randomised population control problem is decidable.

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The Randomised population control problem is decidable.

Theorem [Gimbert, M., Totzke '26]

The Randomised population control problem is EXPTIME-complete.

Sequential Flow Problem (SFP)

[Blumensath Colcombet Parys '16]

Satisfiability in some extension of MSO reduces to SFP*

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+

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First steps in modeling population control problems

Theorem ([Bertrand Dewaskar Genest Gimbert '17])

The Adversarial Population Control Problem is EXPTIME-complete.

Theorem ([Gimbert Mascle Totzke '26b])

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Related work

Explorability for automata on infinite words
[Hazard, Kuperberg, Idir '25], [Bedi, Lehtinen '26]

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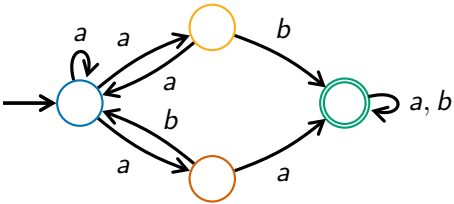
Distribution-based models - continuous distribution instead of discrete population
[Akshay, Genest, Vyas '18], [Doyen, van den Bogaart '22]

Future work

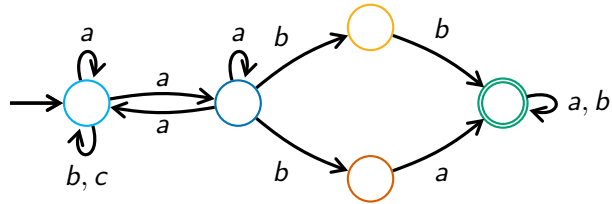
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Allow agents to have different objectives

Allow agents to have different distributions

Allow influence between agents

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Thank you for your attention!